inherently create greater synergy for the defence of our AoR. Besides, we were also able to create more reserves and enhance the inherent offensive defence capabilities in the theatre.

In order to validate the new doctrine, the Strike Corps was asked to conduct an offensive exercise, named Sange Shakti, in the obstacle-ridden plains of the Punjab. Besides launching appropriately grouped task forces within a short time from their peace locations, the exercise also highlighted our capability in network-enabled functioning and the use of UAVs. A number of visits were undertaken by me to review operational readiness and to meet soldiers in border cantonments. I stressed upon thorough knowledge of the operational task and the terrain, and a high state of maintenance of weapon systems and equipment. All ranks should know the ground like the back of their hand. During this tenure, I was honoured by President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam with the Param Vishisht Seva Medal for distinguished services of the highest order at the Rashtrapati Bhawan.

Realizing the growing importance of the role of the media, we held a seminar on army-media relationship and were successful in conducting useful interactive sessions. Many important strategic analysts and media personalities participated in this event. There were unusually heavy monsoon rains in Himachal Pradesh and Punjab in 2004. The cloud burst that took place in the catchment areas of Himachal Pradesh resulted in the flooding of the entire Ambala-Patiala belt. Many people became homeless and there was a huge loss of property and livestock. We made a large number of army aviation sorties with relief material alongwith the air force, and saved lives of many marooned people.

Around September–October 2004, inspired and motivated articles began to appear in the media about the race for the next army chief, as General N.C. Vij was scheduled to retire on 31 January 2005. I was cautioned by some friends that there were a lot of ‘dirty tricks’ played by rivals in such succession battles not only in the armed forces, but in all domains of public service. There was nothing that one could do about it except to guard one’s flanks through friends and well-wishers, and leave the rest to destiny. I was the natural